

SOUNDARYA CHIDAMBARAM

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ACADEMIC POSITIONS

- **Associate Professor (May 2025 – present)**, Department of Political Science, Bucknell University
- **Assistant Professor** (August 2017 – April 2025), Department of Political Science, Bucknell University
- **Senior Fellowship** (January – December 2015), American Institute of Indian Studies [Supported ethnographic field research in India]
- **Scharf Postdoctoral Teaching Fellow** (July 2012–June 2014), Department of Political Science, Johns Hopkins University
- **Visiting Assistant Professor** (August 2011 – May 2012), Department of Political Science, University of Arkansas – Fayetteville

RESEARCH & TEACHING INTERESTS

Comparative Politics

India / South Asia

Social Movements

Development and politics of the Global South

Populism and Politics of the Right

Hindu Nationalism in Urban Slums

Civil Society and Collective Action

Politics of Public Goods Provision

EDUCATION

THE OHIO STATE UNIVERSITY

Columbus, OH

Ph.D. in Political Science, 2012

- **Henry R. Spencer Award for Best Dissertation 2011-12**
- Candidacy Examination (**passed with Distinction**), 2006
- Graduate Minor in Statistical Data Analysis (Dept. of Statistics), 2009

JAWAHARLAL NEHRU UNIVERSITY

New Delhi, India

M. Phil., International Politics, 2004

M.A., International Politics, 2000

UNIVERSITY OF DELHI

New Delhi, India

B.A. (Honors) Journalism, 2000 (University Topper, Ranked Third)

PUBLICATIONS

[NOTE: * indicates work completed while at Bucknell; † indicates work since last review]

Peer-Reviewed

1. *(2020) “How do institutions and infrastructure affect mobilization around public toilets vs. piped water? Examining intra-slum patterns of collective action in Delhi, India”, *World Development*, 132, August 2020
2. (2014) “Play in the States: the Indian Voter’s 2014 Mandate”, *Economic & Political Weekly*, 49:30, July 26, 2014
3. (2012) “The “Right” Kind of Welfare: Seva vs. Patronage in South India’s Urban Slums”, *Asian Survey*, 52: 2, April 2012

Editor-Reviewed

4. *†(Forthcoming) “Chapter 3: Varieties of Authoritarianism”, Amy Atchison (ed.) *Comparative Politics is for Everybody*, University of Toronto Press [Invited Contribution]
5. *† (Forthcoming, in production) “Chapter 7: Authoritarianism”, Manali Desai and Indrajit Roy (eds.) *Cambridge Companion to Indian Politics and Society* [Invited Contribution]

6. ***(2023)** “India’s COVID response: Examining an outlier to explain subnational variation”, in Zhiqun Zhu (ed.) **World Scientific Reference Volume III: Environment, Sustainability and Human Security**, <https://doi.org/10.1142/12807-vol3>
7. ***(2021)** “India’s inexorable path to autocratization: Looking beyond Modi and the populist lens”, in Sten Widmalm (ed.) **Routledge Handbook on Autocratization in South Asia**, <https://doi.org/10.4324/9781003042211> [Invited Contribution]
8. ***(2020)** “The Civil Society Roots of BJP’s Majoritarian Nationalism”, *Georgetown Journal of Asian Affairs, Policy Forum*, Vol. 6, Summer 2020 [Invited Contribution]

In-Process

9. ***†(2024) (completed manuscript)** “Gender, Intersectionality, and Mobilization into the Hindu Nationalist movement: Right-wing organizations’ appeals to practical gender interests”, **submitting to *Politics, Groups, and Identities Journal***
10. (Conference paper in ideation stage for 2024-25) “When do protest movements win against the state? Comparing contentious action by farmers and casual labor in India”

Book Reviews

1. ***(2018)** Amrita Basu, *Violent Conjunctions in Democratic India* (New York: Cambridge University Press, 2015), *Party Politics*, 24:3, 2018, pp. 316-318. [By Invitation]

Op-eds

1. **(2015)** “A Key Criticism of the Vogue Ad Stems from a Misunderstanding”, *The Huffington Post India*, April 7, 2015, http://www.huffingtonpost.in/dr-soundarya-chidambaram/vogue-ad-lets-talk-about-b_7009636.html
2. **(2015)** “What the Urban Poor Want: Challenges of Governance for Aam Aadmi Party”, *The Huffington Post India*, February 11, 2015, http://www.huffingtonpost.in/dr-soundarya-chidambaram/what-the-urban-poor-want-b_6657768.html

TEACHING EXPERIENCE

BUCKNELL UNIVERSITY

Lewisburg, PA

Introduction to Comparative Politics
Qualitative Methods
Comparative Ethnic Politics (Senior Seminar)
Politics of India/South Asia
Globalization, Development, and Social Conflict

JOHNS HOPKINS UNIVERSITY

Baltimore, MD

Ethnic Politics - Fall 2012, 2013
Politics of South Asia - Spring 2013
Globalization, Development, and Social Conflict – Spring 2014

UNIVERSITY OF ARKANSAS – FAYETTEVILLE

Fayetteville, AR

Introduction to Comparative Politics - Fall 2011, Spring 2012;
Ethnic Politics - Spring 2012

THE OHIO STATE UNIVERSITY

Columbus, OH

Independent Graduate Instructor (Summer 2008 – Fall 2011)
Chair’s Recognition for Excellent Teaching, Winter 2009
 Teaching Assistant (2006-2007)

NOTABLE GRANTS, AWARDS AND HONORS

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| • IDEA grant, Faculty Development Council, Bucknell University | 2025 |
| • Senior Research Fellowship 2014-15, American Institute of Indian Studies | 2014 |
| • Henry R. Spencer Best Dissertation Award 2011-12, Dept. of Political Science, Ohio State University | 2012 |
| • Alumni Travel Grant, <i>The Ohio State University</i> | 2010 |

- Research Travel Grant, *Mershon Center for International Security Studies* 2009, 2007
- International Affairs Grant, *Office of International Affairs, The Ohio State University* 2008
- Graduate Fellowship, *The Ohio State University* 2004-2005
- University Topper, B.A. (Honors) Journalism, *Delhi University* 2000, 1998

SELECT PRESENTATIONS

- “Women’s cooptation into grassroots rightwing organizations in urban India”, **2023 MPSA Annual Conference**
- “Brokers, NGOS, and the varying pattern of clientelism in India’s urban slums: A comparison of Delhi and Bangalore”, **2021 APSA Annual Meeting**
- “Why do urban slums coordinate around water but not toilets? Link between the types of public service and collective action in New Delhi’s urban slums”, **Sustainability and Development Conference**, University of Michigan, November 2018
- “Urban Governance and the Limits of Collective Action in New Delhi’s urban slums: the Case of Water vs. Sanitation”, **PANEL SPONSORED BY PROGRAM CHAIRS: Emerging Patterns of Preferences and Participation in Urban and Rural India**, **2018 MPSA Annual Meeting (Also served on the Program Committee as Section Chair for Politics of India and South Asia)**
- “More clientelism, less civil society: The paradox of reforms in Indian slums”, **2017 APSA Annual Meeting**
- “Urban Governance and the Limits of Collective Action in New Delhi’s urban slums: the case of water vs. sanitation”, **2017 ISA Annual Convention**
- **(Invited Talk)** “Research in Play - Community participation: Panacea or pipe dream? Comparing collective action in urban slums in New Delhi and Bangalore”, **Fields of View**, Bangalore, India, August 24, 2015
- “Can the urban poor speak? The role of CBOs in institutionalizing citizen participation in urban slums”, **2014 Annual Conference on South Asia**, Madison, WI, October 17, 2014
- **(Invited Talk)** “India’s urban poor and the politics of welfare”, **Observer Research Foundation**, New Delhi, India, January 14, 2014
- “Civil society or Clientelistic Politics? Sub-national Evidence from India on Public Service Provision”, **2013 MPSA Annual Meeting**, Chicago, April 11-14, 2013
- “Patronage, Welfare Politics, and the Rise of Hindu Nationalism in Urban India”, **2011 APSA Annual Meeting**, Sept 1-4, Seattle
- “Hindu Welfare in South India’s Urban Slums”, **2011 Yale Modern South Asia Workshop**, April 9-10, Yale University

BUCKNELL SERVICE

UNIVERSITY

- Interim Co-Director, Center for Social Science Research, Fall 2025
 - Moderator, “When the Field Shifts: Navigating Research Trajectories and Transitions”, A Social Science Scholars Roundtable, November 2025
- Co-organizer, CSREG’s 2025-26 themed series on “Dimensions of Caste”
 - Moderator, Panel Discussion on “An Introduction to Caste through Lived Experiences”, Oct. 31, 2025
- Committee on Instruction, Social Science Representative (serving since Fall 2025)
- Arts & Sciences Curriculum Committee (Social Science Representative, serving since fall 2023)
- Committee on Admissions and Financial Aid (Social Science Representative, Fall 2022 - Spring 2025, Co-Chair for 2024-25)
- Arts & Sciences Community Council to advance DEI goals (Spring & Fall 2024)
- Steering Committee member, Bucknell Institute of Public Policy
 - Panelist, BIPP Pizza and Policy Panel, “Transnational Feminism and Reproductive Justice: A Comparative Approach” (Spring 2023)
 - Panelist, BIPP Pizza and Policy Panel, “Development in India and Pakistan” (Spring 2019)
- CSREG Faculty Colloquium, “Gender and Civic Participation in India: Why women participate in Hindu Nationalism” (Spring 2023)
- Participant, Community Dialogue Group, Transforming Communities Initiative (Spring 2022)
- L&IT World-Cafe technology sessions to learn remote/hybrid teaching (Summer 2020)

- University Lectureship Committee (Social Science representative, Fall 2018-Spring 2021)
- IRB (Fall 2018 & Spring 2019)
- Panelist, SASA & SAAB's joint panel discussion about Crazy Rich Asians and the representation of Asian people in Western media (Fall 2018)
- Panelist, Social Science Colloquium on Neoliberalism and Precarity of Labor (September 2017)
- Panelist, India-China Relations, organized by the China Institute as part of IREL's International Politics Week (September 2017)

DEPARTMENT

- Second reader for Ellie Fallon's Honors Thesis (Spring 2024)
- TT search REP (Fall 2023)
- VAP Search POLS/IREL Subcommittee (Spring 2021)
- Department DEI Subgroup on Teaching and Campus Community (Spring 2021)
- TT Search REP (Fall 2020)
- Methods courses pilot assessment (Spring 2020)
- TT Search Comparative Politics subcommittee & TT Search International Relations (Fall 2018)
- Second reader for Celina Antonellis's Honors Thesis (Spring 2018)
- VAP searches in International relations and Comparative Politics (Spring 2018)

PROFESSIONAL DEVELOPMENT/SERVICE

- ICPSR Summer Program, 2025, EITM certification
- Panelist, "Whither the Prophets of Hate: A discussion on the Indian general elections of 2024", moderated by Prof. Shahram Azhar (Bucknell), YouTube link: <https://www.youtube.com/live/ynhfIqcHwFQ> (June 2024)
- Panelist, "Narratives on the Ground: Elections Up-Close", Center For Policy Research's (India) How India Votes: 24 Conversations in the run-up to 2024 elections (August 2023), YouTube link: https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=YIuoKqbxo_o
- CSSR workshop on digital scholarship & pedagogy, May 2024
- L&IT's Python workshop, Fall 2023
- CSSR workshops on Voyant and Stata
- Section Chair for South Asia, 2018 MPSA Program Committee
- Panelist and Discussant at APSA September 2021, and MPSA 2022, 2023, & 2024 conferences
- Anonymous reviewer on two manuscripts

SKILLS

- **QUALITATIVE:** Fieldwork/Ethnography - Interviews, participant observation, focus groups; Text Analysis/Voyant
- **QUANTITATIVE:** R, STATA, Network Analysis, Regression
- **LANGUAGES:** English, Hindi (native), Tamil (fluent)